

Byzantine art

After Constantine transferred the main capital of his Empire from Rome to Byzantium (renamed Constantinople), a new style of art developed, lasting from c.330–1453. Byzantine images and icons derived from elements of Greek, Roman and Egyptian art, and appeared in Constantinople, Ravenna, Venice, Sicily, Greece and Russia. Concerned with religious expression, a strong sense of order dominates the art. The first examples appear in mosaics and frescoes decorating domed churches that were built in great proportions to express the omnipresence of God. Encaustic wooden panel paintings were produced in monasteries. More decorative than lifelike, flat, stylized images of holy figures predominated, often featuring symbolism. Sculpture was mostly limited to small relief carvings in ivory, usually for book covers, reliquary boxes and similar holy objects, but embroidery, metal- and enamel-work flourished. Although aspects of Byzantine art changed over time, it remained roughly consistent, its artists anonymous. In fact, religious imagery itself became so venerated that its use was opposed by some Eastern Church authorities.



Mosaic of Christ Pantocrator in the Hagia Sophia, Istanbul, c.1261